

The Coca-Cola Company

Reassurance from Resilience

Beyond clearing the (admittedly lowered) bar for the quarter, KO reinforced to the market the best-in-class top-line visibility inherent in its business.

We think KO's +6% OSG in 3Q could well prove to be the best top-line print among Staples this earnings season, but when taking a longer-term lens, we need to be mindful that volumes are still soft. That said, KO continues to show that it is not standing still in navigating the current backdrop while also still laying groundwork for long-term growth. And this commitment to growth is also made evident in what we see as increasingly mindful cost management that highlights ongoing reflection on ways to optimize the P&L and fund further reinvestment ahead.

KO: Quarterly and Annual EPS (USD)

FY Dec	2024	2025			2026			Change y/y	
	Actual	Old	New	Cons	Old	New	Cons	2025	2026
Q1	0.72A	0.73A	0.73A	0.73A	0.80E	0.84E	0.78E	1%	15%
Q2	0.84A	0.87A	0.87A	0.87A	0.94E	0.93E	0.92E	4%	7%
Q3	0.77A	0.78E	0.82A	0.78E	0.85E	0.88E	0.84E	6%	7%
Q4	0.55A	0.59E	0.56E	0.60E	0.62E	0.57E	0.64E	2%	2%
Year	2.88A	2.97E	2.98E	2.98E	3.20E	3.22E	3.19E	3%	8%
P/E	24.7		23.9			22.1			

Consensus numbers are from Bloomberg received on 21-Oct-2025; 12:50 GMT
Source: Barclays Research

KO **OVERWEIGHT**
Unchanged

U.S. CHPC & Beverages **NEUTRAL**
Unchanged

Price Target **USD 77.00**
raised 8% from USD 71.00

Price (21-Oct-25) **USD 71.22**

Potential Upside/Downside **+8.1%**

Source: Bloomberg, Barclays Research

Market Cap (USD mn) **306507**

Shares Outstanding (mn) **4303.67**

Free Float (%) **81.94**

52 Wk Avg Daily Volume (mn) **16.9**

Dividend Yield (%) **2.86**

Return on Equity TTM (%) **45.12**

Current BVPS (USD) **7.26**

Source: Bloomberg

Price Performance **Exchange-NYSE**

52 Week range **USD 74.38-60.62**



Source: IDC
[Link to Barclays Live for interactive charting](#)

U.S. CHPC & Beverages

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U.S. CHPC & Beverages

NEUTRAL

The Coca-Cola Company (KO)

OVERWEIGHT

Income statement (\$mn)	2024A	2025E	2026E	2027E	CAGR
Revenue	46,897	48,210	50,920	53,825	4.7%
EBITDA (adj)	15,160	16,216	17,459	18,721	7.3%
EBIT (adj)	14,085	15,059	16,237	17,429	7.4%
Pre-tax income (adj)	15,333	16,230	17,387	18,691	6.8%
Net income (adj)	12,463	12,857	13,896	14,939	6.2%
EPS (adj) (\$)	2.88	2.98	3.22	3.46	6.3%
Diluted shares (mn)	4,320.3	4,313.5	4,313.0	4,313.0	-0.1%
DPS (\$)	1.94	2.04	2.12	2.21	4.4%
Margin and return data	2024A	2025E	2026E	2027E	Average
Gross margin (%)	61.1	61.3	61.6	61.9	61.5
EBITDA (adj) margin (%)	32.3	33.6	34.3	34.8	33.8
EBIT (adj) margin (%)	30.0	31.2	31.9	32.4	31.4
Pre-tax (adj) margin (%)	32.7	33.7	34.1	34.7	33.8
Net (adj) margin (%)	26.6	26.7	27.3	27.8	27.1
ROIC (%)	25.6	26.0	26.8	27.4	26.5
ROA (%)	11.4	11.7	12.1	12.3	11.9
ROE (%)	47.3	50.5	45.7	41.5	46.2
Balance sheet and cash flow (\$mn)	2024A	2025E	2026E	2027E	CAGR
Cash and equivalents	10,828	9,938	12,167	15,259	12.1%
Total assets	100,549	101,901	107,630	113,770	4.2%
Short and long-term debt	44,522	45,722	45,722	45,722	0.9%
Total liabilities	74,177	76,417	77,196	77,752	1.6%
Net debt/(funds)	29,951	32,041	29,812	26,720	-3.7%
Shareholders' equity	26,372	25,484	30,434	36,019	11.0%
Change in working capital	-6,234	-7,554	-358	-96	N/A
Cash flow from operations	6,805	5,945	13,587	14,967	30.0%
Capital expenditure	-2,064	-2,218	-2,190	-2,314	N/A
Free cash flow	4,741	3,728	11,397	12,653	38.7%
Valuation and leverage metrics	2024A	2025E	2026E	2027E	Average
P/E (adj) (x)	24.7	23.9	22.1	20.6	22.8
EV/sales (x)	6.8	6.7	6.3	5.9	6.4
EV/EBITDA (adj) (x)	21.0	19.8	18.3	16.9	19.0
EV/EBIT (adj) (x)	22.7	21.3	19.6	18.1	20.4
Equity FCF yield (%)	1.5	1.2	3.7	4.1	2.6
P/BV (x)	11.7	12.1	10.1	8.5	10.6
Dividend yield (%)	2.7	2.9	3.0	3.1	2.9
Total debt/capital (%)	62.8	64.2	60.0	55.9	60.7
Net debt/EBITDA (adj) (x)	2.0	2.0	1.7	1.4	1.8
Selected operating metrics	2024A	2025E	2026E	2027E	Average
Organic sales growth (%)	12.0	5.3	5.3	5.7	7.1
Volume growth (%)	2.0	0.1	1.5	3.4	1.7
Price growth (%)	11.0	5.3	3.9	2.3	5.6

Note: FY End Dec

Source: Company data, Bloomberg, Barclays Research

Price (21-Oct-2025) **USD 71.22**
 Price Target **USD 77.00**

Why OVERWEIGHT?

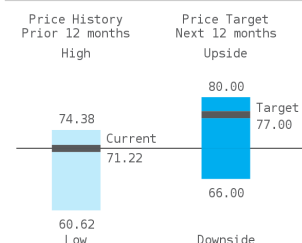
We expect KO's comprehensive transformation to re-accelerate the top and bottom line. As the company demonstrates an ability to sustainably deliver its algorithm, we expect more valuation credit to be given.

Upside case USD 80.00

Our upside case assumes that KO trades at a +17.5% premium to the more defensive, multi-national peers on upside 2026 EPS of \$3.28.

Downside case USD 66.00

Our downside case assumes that KO trades in-line with the more defensive, multi-national peers on downside 2026 EPS of \$3.19.

Upside/Downside scenarios

Reassurance from Resilience

What to do with the stock: Results were received favorably yesterday (KO +4.1% vs. XLP -0.5%), with UCV coming in ahead of the (meaningfully lowered) bar and OSG at the high end of the company's long-term algorithm (+6% – albeit fully driven by price/mix) that we expect could well prove to be the best OSG Staples print over C3Q earnings. And we think this best-in-class

visibility into solid top-line momentum is what keeps KO as a core Staples holding and supports our reiterated Overweight rating. But that's not to say the market volume growth isn't critical, so we also think KO's focus on driving more balanced top-line growth in 2026 (and actually seeing that come to fruition) will remain key to the conversation.

Time and time again KO makes plain it is not standing still in navigating the current dynamic macro backdrop... To be sure, we recognize the reality that volumes remain soft (i.e., UCV +1% in the quarter was better than some feared but also well shy of our original expectation for +2.6% coming out of the 2Q print in July). As a result, we've been keen to keep pressing on the conversation of what KO and its bottling partners are doing by category and by market to protect (or accelerate) volumes. Recall that several examples of the System tactically adapting YTD had to do with Mexico and India, and these markets came in below original expectations for the quarter – but that is not to say we don't see signs of success from the System's efforts. A case in point is the return to value share gains in Latin America this quarter, after declines in Mexico (and Chile) over 1H25 fully offset gains in Brazil and Argentina. And while we certainly don't want to point to weather as an excuse, we do wonder how much worse Mexico and India might have looked in 3Q absent tactical initiatives in light of what proved to be difficult rainy and monsoon conditions, respectively, especially early in the quarter.

And importantly, there has been nothing in our discussions to suggest a major uptick in competitive pressure from more local or regional brands that has created a significant overhang for KO's portfolio to overcome given the company continues to gain value share among total NARTD. That said, CEO James Quincey did acknowledge some increased "dynamism" among regional players, but the System is responding in kind with stepped up front line resources where necessary.

...at the same time, we see the company laying groundwork for the long-term future health of this business. Even where System volume-centric efforts aren't yet readily apparent given continued broader category or economic malaise, we believe the company is creating additional torque to an eventual recovery. All while managing near-term curve balls, KO and its bottlers continue to invest for long-term growth across the footprint. The company sounded as confident as ever to us in the long-term attractiveness of NARTD and its ability to drive continued share gains over the long term, with the latter supported in part by increasing focus on brand building specifically as the company gets closer to the end of its refranchising goals following the 40% India stake sale that closed in July and upcoming sale of the majority of its CCBA stake that is expected to close by YE26.

KO's mindful approach to spending was clear in this quarter's results. Cost management came in better than we expected, driving operating margin expansion even with marketing spend increasing YoY. We'd think this is in part a manifestation of 1) the merits of more thoughtfully leveraging scale within marketing and productivity (which, recall, had been a key takeaway from this year's CAGNY presentation that we discussed in [The Coca-Cola Company: CAGNY Feedback](#), 02/18/25) and 2) certain tech-driven cost savings that we'd expect the company will continue to unlock in the years ahead.

Looking into 2026 specifically, we'd note our model wasn't lacking for EPS growth in the first place (BARCe ~8% heading into yesterday's print), so we were struck by Mr. Quincey's preliminary mention of organizational restructuring next year. We don't yet know what this will exactly entail or to what magnitude, but we're intrigued by yet another example of KO exploring ways to optimize its business – particularly given it's not as if we think a restructuring is needed in order to fund reinvestment for long-term growth. Still, we can appreciate proactively taking such actions when you can, rather than waiting until you have to. It remains to be seen whether the changes are additive or rather an enabler of the long-term algorithm for ~50 bps annually of

underlying operating margin expansion, but for our part we remain comfortably anchored to +8% EPS growth in 2026 and look to future discussions for more color on this front.

Changes to the model. We raise our FY25E EPS by +1.5c to \$2.98 (+3.3% growth YoY), driven by the 3Q ~4c beat that is partially offset by a ~2.5c reduction to our 4Q25 EPS (now \$0.56). And we raise our FY26E EPS by +2c to \$3.22 (+8.1% YoY) based on the slightly higher FY25 base along with incremental FX tailwind beyond what we previously contemplated.

The ~20 bps increase to our FY25E OSG (to +5.3%) is driven by the 3Q outperformance, while our 4QE of +4.3% is unchanged at a high level (although now skewed more heavily to price/mix than our prior model). More specifically, we look for 4QE concentrate volumes to hold roughly stable QoQ (BARCe +0.3% from +1.1% previously and vs. flat in 3Q), with the modest growth aided by 1 extra selling day and sequentially improving execution that is offset by the tougher comp the business must lap in 4Q. We now look for a 4QE UCV decline (-0.7% vs. +0.2% previously) in light of our softened concentrate assumption. We raise our 4QE price/mix to +3.9% from +3.1%. Of note, we tempered the FX tailwind to our 4QE top line (now +0.6% from +1.7%) and embedded a bigger drag to EPS from currency than our prior model, which is the primary driver of our softened EPS outlook for the final quarter of the year. Shifting back to the full-year outlook, we look for consolidated net sales growth of +2.8% inclusive of a -1.8% FX headwind for the year and a -0.7% structural drag. We model +20 bps of gross margin expansion (to 61.3%) and a ~100 bps decline in opex as a percent of sales that translates to a 31.2% operating margin this year.

In FY26E, we now look for more price/mix-led OSG (now +3.9% from +2.9%) with volumes tempered by ~110 bps to +1.5%. We look for FY26E OSG of +5.3%, which coupled with a slightly stronger +0.3% FX tailwind translates to +5.6% consolidated net sales growth. The slightly better currency outlook flowed through favorably in the P&L and drove the ~15 bps increase in our FY26E EPS growth forecast (to +8.1%), meanwhile our underlying margin assumptions are unchanged. Of note, we do not embed the impact of the planned CCBA stake sale that was announced yesterday, but we'd expect the P&L impact to follow the same logic as KO's other refranchising transactions – that is, top line dilution and somewhat less EPS dilution thanks to margin tailwinds. That said, the degree of impact that comes through 2026 will depend on when the stake sale closes (expected by YE26, so it's possible the impact is more of a 2027 event).

We are raising our PT to \$77. Our valuation methodology assumes a +15% premium to the more defensive, multi-national peers (a ~23.8x multiple) on a P/E basis on our 2026 EPS estimate of \$3.22. Our prior price target of \$71 assumed a +HSD% premium to immediate peers or a ~22.2x multiple on a P/E basis on our CY26 EPS estimate of \$3.20. Our widened premium reflects the best-in-class top-line visibility and attractive flexibility we see into +HSD EPS growth next year.

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The Coca-Cola Company (KO, 21-Oct-2025, USD 71.22), Overweight/Neutral, CD/CE/D/E/J/K/L/M/N

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U.S. CHPC & Beverages

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Constellation Brands (STZ)	Coty Inc. (COTY)	Edgewell Personal Care Company (EPC)
Energizer Holdings, Inc (ENR)	International Flavors & Fragrances (IFF)	Kenvue Inc. (KVUE)
Keurig Dr Pepper (KDP)	Kimberly-Clark Corp. (KMB)	Molson Coors Beverage Company (TAP)

Newell Brands Inc. (NWL)	ODDITY Tech Ltd. (ODD)	Olaplex Holdings, Inc. (OLPX)
PepsiCo Inc. (PEP)	Primo Brands Corporation (PRMB)	Procter & Gamble (PG)
Reynolds Consumer Products (REYN)	The Coca-Cola Company (KO)	The Estée Lauder Companies (EL)

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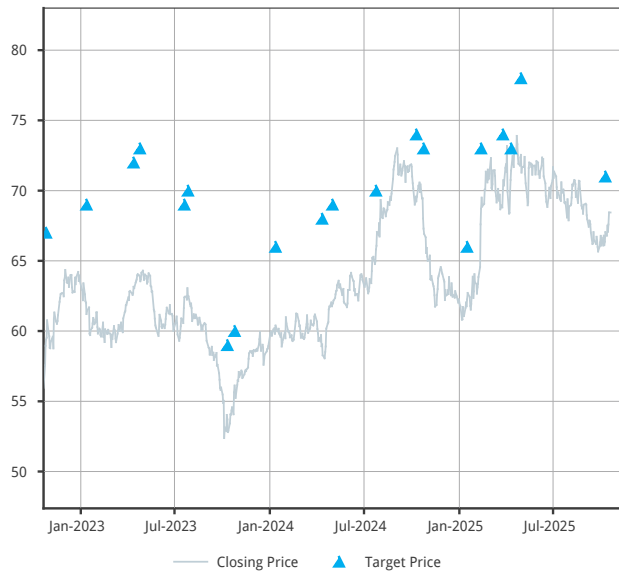
Stock Rating: **OVERWEIGHT**

Industry View: **NEUTRAL**

Closing Price: **USD 71.22** (21-Oct-2025)

Rating and Price Target Chart - USD (as of 21-Oct-2025)

Currency=USD



Source: IDC, Barclays Research

[Link to Barclays Live for interactive charting](#)

Publication Date	Closing Price*	Rating	Adjusted Price Target
10-Oct-2025	66.12		71.00
30-Apr-2025	72.35		78.00
11-Apr-2025	70.76		73.00
26-Mar-2025	68.95		74.00
12-Feb-2025	67.60		73.00
16-Jan-2025	61.77		66.00
24-Oct-2024	68.01		73.00
10-Oct-2024	69.57		74.00
24-Jul-2024	64.96		70.00
01-May-2024	61.77		69.00
11-Apr-2024	59.72		68.00
12-Jan-2024	59.81		66.00
25-Oct-2023	55.64		60.00
11-Oct-2023	54.03		59.00
27-Jul-2023	63.05		70.00
20-Jul-2023	61.64		69.00
25-Apr-2023	63.95		73.00
13-Apr-2023	62.69		72.00
12-Jan-2023	61.21		69.00
26-Oct-2022	58.95		67.00

On 21-Oct-2022, prior to any intra-day change that may have been published, the rating for this security was Overweight, and the adjusted price target was 62.00.

Source: Bloomberg, Barclays Research

*This is the closing price referenced in the publication, which may not be the last available closing price at the time of publication.

Historical stock prices and price targets may have been adjusted for stock splits and dividends.

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Valuation Methodology: Our price target of \$77 is based on a ~23.8x P/E reflecting a +15% premium to the more defensive, multinational peers on our CY26 EPS estimate of \$3.22.

Risks which May Impede the Achievement of the Barclays Research Valuation and Price Target: 1) FX headwinds force downward revision of estimates, 2) Slowdown in CSD category growth, 3) More sugar taxes cloud the dialogue, 4) Deterioration in North American pricing environment would hurt results.

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U.S. CHPC & Beverages

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